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"All the News
That's Fit to Print"

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, partly sunny, dry, light winds, high 61. **Tonight,** partly cloudy, dry, light winds, low 50. **Tomorrow,** sun peaking through clouds, high 67. Weather map appears on Page 25.

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LINDSEY WASSON/ASSOCIATED PRESS

Early voting in Anchorage. A drama is playing out in Alaska, where two men with the same name are running for the U.S. Senate.

Trump's Speech Becomes More Vulgar and Muddled

His Appearances Onstage at 80 Are Raising Questions About Age and Stability

By PETER BAKER and DYLAN FREEDMAN

CHILLICOTHE, Ohio — As he opened his speech at a recent campaign rally in Greenville, N.C., President Trump told the story of the Willie Horton crime case that helped sink the presidential campaign of the Democrat Michael S. Dukakis in 1988.

And then, 30 minutes later, still speaking at the same rally to the same audience from the same lectern, Mr. Trump told the same Willie Horton story all over again, using some of the same language (and getting the facts wrong both times).

Mr. Trump, who last year became the oldest person ever inaugurated as president and turned 80 in June, has demonstrated physical stamina as he barnstorms the country in advance of midterm elections. But his performances on the road and at the White House this fall have produced many head-scratching moments that have revived questions about his age and stability.

He can be forgetful and repetitive. He is more long-winded, more profane and more absolutist than when he ran for president a decade ago. His rambling speeches seem even more garbled at times. He makes comments that leave people wondering what he is talking about or that sound like he is saying something he is not. And even for a president who has never fully observed the norms of the office, he seems more willing to say things no other president would say.

He declared that at an unfenced construction site, "only a Hispanic could survive that fall." He wants to ban immigrants from Norway "because I didn't get the Nobel Prize." He says "I don't give a damn" if he is seen as caring more about oil company profits than struggling workers. He mispronounces the Strait of Hormuz as the "Hormone Strait." He has told supporters to "cheat like hell" in Tuesday's elections. He says military leakers "should be shot." And then there is his baffling fixation with admiring men's posteriors.

Even Mr. Trump seems astonished at times by what comes out of his mouth — and by how much his supporters embrace him nonetheless. "I could say the stupidest things and you'd clap. 'Oh, I love you so,'" he marveled at a recent rally in Clarksville, Tenn. "But we don't say the stupidest things," he quickly added. "We say things of common sense. We say things that make sense."

ALEX KENT/THE NEW YORK TIMES

A Times review of President Trump's speeches found significant changes since 2015.

For Mr. Trump, making sense often places second to having fun at rallies, and some outrageous remarks appear aimed at generating a laugh. His allies say too much is made of comments that are really just jokes. He has always been a provocative speaker, willing to outrage for the sake of outrage. Mr. Trump defends his stream-of-consciousness rambling as a "brilliant" speaking style that he calls "the weave."

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Will Spoilers Actually Spoil In Midterms?

By REID J. EPSTEIN

WASHINGTON — Sly maneuvering around third-party candidates is a time-honored, bipartisan tradition in politics.

Democrats and Republicans alike have long stealthily tried to help little-known names on the ballot who might siphon votes from the opposing party's nominees. The issue has suddenly become a top midterm story line because of remarkable drama in Alaska, where Democrats carried out a gambit to place a second Dan Sullivan on the ballot, alongside a Republican senator with the same name.

But several other midterm battlegrounds also have outsider candidates who could swing a close race.

In Ohio, Republicans have spent more than $2.2 million to promote a socialist candidate in the state's vital Senate race, aiming to pull votes from the Democratic nominee, former Senator Sherrod Brown.

In Virginia, a Republican group has sent mailers highlighting the Democratic-leaning positions of a self-described "radical centrist" running as an independent in a competitive House race.

And in Nebraska, both major parties are jockeying to help minor candidates peel votes away from Senator Pete Ricketts, the Republican incumbent, and his Democratic-backed independent challenger, Dan Osborn.

With modern elections often decided by extremely thin margins and billions of dollars sloshing through campaigns, both parties have ample incentives and opportunities to gain an edge through mischief involving third parties.

The jockeying around spoiler candidates is widely considered a legal yet shadowy part of political campaigning that has gone on for decades. The Sullivan episode in Alaska is far from the first time that multiple candidates with the same name have run for the same office, with the lesser-known one often deliberately trying to confuse voters. There was even an Eddie Murphy movie in 1992

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Kennedy Backs Off Plan to Ban an Opioid

Allowing Some Kratom After Push for Donor

By CHRISTINA JEWETT

Three months ago, federal health officials announced that the government planned to ban a potent opioid that Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. said "put American lives at risk."

The substance was a highly addictive compound derived from the kratom leaf, a plant from Southeast Asia that is in powders and tinctures sold as energy boosters and pain relievers in convenience stores and vape shops across the United States. The ban was crucial, the officials said, "to avoid an imminent hazard to public safety."

Last month, the government reversed course.

Mr. Kennedy announced on Oct. 9 that his department had "followed the science" and decided to allow some levels of the compound.

The policy U-turn came after a number of kratom companies discovered the substance in products marketed as "natural" in recent months. The manager of a large kratom distribution company, faced with evidence of the compound in products at the center of several wrongful death lawsuits against him, mounted a concerted lobbying push.

The executive, David Gabbay, and his wife, Maya, had been giving steadily to Republican candidates and campaign committees this year, reaching about $2.9 million on Oct. 12. Mac Haddow, the leader of an advocacy group funded heavily by the company Mr. Gabbay manages, said he went to the White House to plead his case.

Then Mr. Kennedy and officials from the Drug Enforcement Ad-

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JUAN ARREDONDO FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

James Gusmer and his team marking and measuring the New York City Marathon course.

Making Sure That 26.2 Miles Have Been Precisely Measured

By LUIS FERRÉ-SADURNÍ

On a mild morning in September, James Gusmer pedaled past potholes, meandering buses and double-parked cars on the edges of city streets, often going against traffic.

He stole regular glances at the small box attached to the axel of his front wheel, the gears inside counting fractions of wheel revolutions.

Then, after exactly one mile, he squeezed the brakes, reached into his bottle cage and pulled out a can of spray paint. He dashed a yellow line on the curb.

"It can get a little dicey," said Mr. Gusmer, whose job requires him to painstakingly measure the route of the New York City Marathon.

As the director of timing and competition management at New York Road Runners, the nonprofit that organizes and produces the marathon, Mr. Gusmer has a crucial task: to help ensure that the race is as close as possible to exactly 26 miles and 385 yards.

The stakes are high. Nearly 60,000 runners will participate in an event that will bring hundreds of millions of dollars to the city. A miscalibrated course can invalidate the finishing times of runners who hope to qualify for other marathons.

Then there is the debacle of the 1981 New York Marathon. Alberto Salazar appeared to break the world record by 20 seconds. Later, the course was found to be more than 160 yards too short.

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Netanyahu Exceeded Expectations Using an Old Trick: Playing on Israelis' Fears

By DAVID M. HALBFINGER

NEWS ANALYSIS

JERUSALEM — Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu didn't win Israel's election. He certainly didn't lose, either. Neither he nor his chief opponent has a clear path to form a government.

What is clear is that Mr. Netanyahu performed far better than anyone carrying so much political baggage would have any reason to expect.

His opponents, led by the former military chief Gadi Eisenkot, sailed into Tuesday's fateful vote having consistently led in the polls and confident that their goal, an outright majority relying only on predominantly Jewish parties, was within reach.

Mr. Netanyahu limped into Election Day by comparison, dragging the public's fury over his failure to take responsibility for the Oct. 7, 2023, Hamas-led attack; its weariness with a four-year term in which he tried to gain power at the expense of the courts; and its frustration with his refusal to force ultra-Orthodox Jews to share in the sacrifice of military service.

And yet, initial results in Tuesday's election showed that his Likud party outperformed all others. The result has left Jewish opposition leaders pondering an exceedingly difficult choice.

They now can give up on conclusively defeating Mr. Netanya-

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Covering the Tiananmen Square massacre in 1989 showed Nicholas Kristof examples of true courage. It also taught him hard lessons. PAGE 17

SPECIAL SECTION

Fine Arts & Exhibits

With new artists, new audiences and new technology, the world of art and museums is pushing boundaries and redefining what creativity looks like.

SUNDAY STYLES

A Learned Lepidopterist

Violet Clinton is a high school junior by day and a moth researcher by night. She has cataloged more than 11,300 insects in a seven-month study. PAGE 1

SUNDAY BUSINESS

Fighting a 'Billionaire Tax'

Rich Californians opposing a ballot measure that would impose a one-time 5 percent wealth tax have raised more than $333 million. PAGE 4

SUNDAY OPINION

The Editorial Board PAGE 11

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